issues relating to national security. According to this view, Nehru sought to ‘retain the core British strategic framework’ for India’s defense while ‘shedding off its imperial and colonial façade’. [23] Muni states that India treated each of the three Himalayan kingdoms with ‘nuanced differences’ in terms of sovereignty and degrees of independence. Sikkim was viewed ‘as a protectorate’ (which was later absorbed as a state of the Indian Union in 1974), Bhutan ‘evolved’ into a sovereign state and Nepal was always considered ‘a fully sovereign’ country.[24] The treaties India signed with each of these countries – Bhutan (1948), Nepal (1950) and Sikkim (1950) reflected these differences. Muni states that while minor changes occurred over the years, what remained intact was this policy of ‘keeping the neighbouring countries free from adversarial strategic influences and forces’.[25]

Muni echoes views expressed as early as 1951 by international relations scholar Werner Levi. Levi stated that when it came to India’s immediate neighbours Nehru was ‘very much the realist’ who understood that in a Westphalian system of states ‘national survival is the primary aim of foreign policy’. For Levi, policies adopted towards Hyderabad, Kashmir, Afghanistan and Nepal demonstrate the realist aspect of Nehruvianism. Levi quotes Nehru as defending India’s interference in the internal affairs of Nepal on the grounds that ‘much as we appreciate the independence of Nepal, we cannot risk our own security by any happenings in Nepal which permit that barrier being crossed or which otherwise weaken our frontiers’.[26]

Beyond the immediate neighbourhood, Nehru wanted India to find its place in the sun by playing a leadership role in Asia and on the global stage. He acknowledged that India was too weak militarily or economically to stand up to the superpowers. India had to adopt a policy whereby it could maintain its independence and yet be part of the world, receiving support for its development from all major powers. Non-alignment – the notion of